

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 4

Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: No Date Given

Coverage Date: 1978 AD - 2000 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

Background • Gender Roles and the Extended Family

The Luguru have never had a centralized political system (Beidelman: 1967; Young et al: 1960). The whole society is decentralized and the principal political organization is mainly through the lineage. Women are important since they are the ones who elect the council of elders. There is general care for elders so that old age is not feared as it carries with it a sense of high respect. Death has a special place in the society and is considered to be the time when an adult enters into the spiritual world of ancestors. There is a special ceremony when a person who has already gone through the rites of passage to adulthood dies. The head of the lineage gives yearly sacrifices to the ancestors in a special ceremony called, "tambiko" which is highly respected by believers of the two dominant religions, Islam and Christianity. It is the time when communication with the dead ancestors is effected. Sacrifices to ensure rainfall and hence good harvest as well as human and crop fertility are made. The ideology behind all these is the appeasement of the ancestors. It is important to note also that there is seniority based on age group. This is evident particularly during the female initiation rites when hierarchy comes out clearly. Under normal circumstances those born earlier would be respected and would have more rights (tombo). Infertility is feared and treated with suspicion. Sisters of a childless woman would arrange for an adoption of one of their own children. When a childless woman dies then her property would automatically go to her sister's children but never to her brother's.

[428
Inheritance](#)
[561
Age Stratification](#)
[562
Gender Status](#)
[597
Adoption](#)
[613
Lineages](#)
[621
Community Structure](#)
[623
Community Councils](#)
[666
Elections](#)
[761
Life And Death](#)
[769
Cult Of The Dead](#)
[782
Prayers And Sacrifices](#)
[796
Organized Ceremonial](#)

888
Status And Treatment
Of The Aged

Traditionally people work on each other's farm on rotation basis (ubava). There is no remuneration apart from the locally-brewed beer offered at the host's place once the work has been accomplished. Several compounds in the same hamlet share solidarity and traditional rites are performed on common ground (Paul Jean Luc, 1986). Different hamlets in the neighborhood have a joking relationship called "utani" or "ugongo". These relationships used to be very important, much more than they are today. They have a reciprocal relationship in terms of helping each other in accomplishing farming tasks or any other communal activity. "Utani" joking relationships exist in different ethnic groups in Tanzania. The Luguru have joking relationship with several other ethnic groups including the Wa-Mbunga, Wa-Pogoro, Wa-Nyamwezi, and Wa-Sukuma. (Lucas, 1974). Normally one shares food with others.

629
Multi-Ethnic
Community Relations

There is a distinct division of labor between sexes. As in most other societies women normally carry out the usual house chores and child rearing. Other indoor activities such as the making of baskets, sleeping-mats, and pottery are also carried out by women. Young girls look after their younger siblings, help their mothers to carry water and go in search of firewood. Men are involved in the making of farming tools such as hoes and axes. Apart from petty errands young boys help in these activities too. In terms of child delivery practices, men are complete outsiders. In fact this division is narrowed down to only those women who have ever borne children. Infertile women (wagumba) are not included making childbearing very special with a status of its own. Traditional Birth Attendants and other women herbalists are highly esteemed as they would go all out to prescribe medicinal herb so as to stimulate fertility. In this matrilineal society, medical practice relating to the use of medicinal herb associated with reproductive health of women is highly valued. In the past there existed a division of labor between clans too (Beidelman, 1967). For example, the Chuma clan originally manufactured iron tools while the  5 Matze clan specialized in cultivation of Sorghum and millet. Division of labor at the clan level is however no longer evident now. Despite these divisions, unity within the lineage has always remained strong.

883
Adolescent Activities

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)